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The Whites think too much

Author(S): Parin, Paul, Morgenthaler, Fritz, Parin-Matthey, Goldy, Schütze, Frieda

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THE INFLUENCE OF SOCIETY ON THE INDIVIDUAL

The chief difference to the common European development lies in the fact that no objects have been internalized to which prohibitions with threats of punishment adhere. For this reason the more sensitive adjustment to the environment cannot be made on the basis of internalized models, as is the case with us. Their approach to their fellow men and the way they regulate their conduct is determined above all by the possibility of more or less direct or sublimized appeasement. Wrong conduct leads to a feeling of frustration and not to a guilt feeling and a need for punishment. Public opinion tells the individual what he must do to avoid a failure.

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Seen from the "outside", the social structure has the following effect on the analysands: It soon rejects certain definite basic attitudes by charging them with qualms of conscience. The major part of regulation is left to the individual's adjustment (acquired in childhood) to the possibilities of gratification that society offers. Only when the individual's inner balance of like and dislike becomes unclear, when he no longer knows what he wants, or if fulfillment of his wishes is harmful to his environment, the environment will — by way of supplement — interfere, with "public disgrace". On the whole, society will not threaten punishment by the feeling of shame, but by the withdrawal of satisfaction and love.

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The clan-conscience achieves its power from the individual's need for being unified, for appeasement, security, and the participation he has retained from the pre-Oedipal relationship 485 with his mother. The fulfillment of wishes, the happy oneness with the mother during the years of babyhood, give almost all analysands a good self-awareness, a feeling of identity with their people and of their role in society.

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As a further example of how a custom can be psychologically understood we choose their system of "mocking-relationship". (68) Their ceremony of greeting (and a few other customs) can be associated with mockery.

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The deep psychological meaning of this institution seems obvious if one regards the content of the custom as being an undisguised expression of the unconscious. The specific meaning would be that the mocking relationship serves to safeguard the incest prohibition. But our observation of individuals who follow the custom leads to another interpretation.

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During a collective, rhythmical entertainment (dance, 507 485 cont. singing) or during cooperative efforts there is, as a rule, no mocking or greeting. Non-collective occupations such as weaving, wood-cutting (or our conversations) are, however, interrupted by the exchange of greetings or by joking. The individual must take part in this, not the active group. If the mockery or greeting miscarries because the partner does not give a proper reply, or because the tension becomes too great, emotions will often break out. The mocking relationship may be permanent or arise as the result of momentary tension. Yet it always appears only "as required". This often became clear during the analysis. For example, if an attitude of the analyst led to the fact that the analysand felt dependent on him, as on a patron, he might address a ritual joke to the White. This immediately restored his self-awareness and made possible another form of transference. Sometimes an exchange of small gifts accompanies or replaces the mocking statements. This exchange has been described as the original meaning of the mocking relationship. The Dogon explain their custom by saying that mocking leads to an exchange of life-force (nyama) between the participants and increases the vital energy of both.

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(68). See pp. 59–60.

*755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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